Central Asia to Graeco-Bactrian kingdoms in what is now Afghanistan, and to Persia and northern India, brought new cultural influences, ideas and different products. Buddhism entered China from northern India at the time of the Han dynasty. The Tang dynasty inaugurated an unusually cosmopolitan era in Chinese history. The Tang capital Changan was one of the largest cities of the time and had traders from India, Persia, the Arab empire and the Central Asian kingdoms. Paintings from the period testify to the popularity of garments of Central Asian design, including long and slim-fitting tunics and breeches. Tang women are even depicted wearing pants and riding horses in Central Asian style, though this practice was derided in some of the Tang chronicles by the more conservative elements. Horses from Ferghana in Central Asia were greatly prized and figure prominently in Chinese painting and sculpture over several dynasties. Indian sugar-making techniques came to China during the Tang dynasty, [2] and the produce was known as ‘rock honey’. In the course of the Ming dynasty (1368–1644), fine Chinese porcelain borrowed advanced techniques from Persia, including the use of cobalt imported from that country, which gave the unusual blue lustre to Ming vases.

During the Mongol Yuan dynasty (1271–1368 CE), China was the eastern component of an empire that stretched from the Pacific to Europe and thus took part in a truly global market, with an unprecedented volume of exchange of not only a wide variety of goods but also of new ideas and exposure to different cultures. But these phases of relative openness were interspersed with phases of relative insularity and rejection of external influences. Except for a brief period when the Ming emperor commissioned the great voyages into the Indian Ocean by Zheng He (mentioned in Chapter 2), China retreated into a more inward-looking epoch that lasted right up to the end of the Maoist era and the inauguration of the spectacularly successful Reform and Opening-Up period from 1978 onwards.

But until then, through much of its history, the very size of the country and a relatively self-sufficient economy made such insularity feasible, particularly with an interconnected and flourishing domestic market. Trade